

100 Must-Know Chinese Idioms: Unlocking Chinese Culture

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Idioms are an essential part of the language and culture of any country. With thousands of years of history, Chinese boasts a treasure trove of idioms that are both rich in meaning and deeply rooted in tradition. In this article, **Ni Hao Ma** introduces 100 beautiful and commonly used **Chinese idioms**, complete with their meanings, to help you gain deeper insights into Chinese culture.

100 Beautiful Chinese Idioms

Chinese idioms, known as "chengyu" (成语), are concise, often metaphorical expressions that convey a deeper meaning, usually derived from historical stories or classical literature.

Chinese idioms are often concise and to the point, yet they carry profound life philosophies, practical wisdom, and valuable lessons passed down through generations. Let's dive into 100 of the most meaningful **Chinese idioms**, along with their explanations to help you better understand them:

No.	Idiom	Pinyin	Meaning	Explanation
1	一箭双雕	yī jiàn shuāng diāo	One arrow, two eagles	Achieving two goals with a single action.
2	画蛇添足	huà shé tiān zú	Drawing a snake and adding feet	Doing something unnecessary or excessive.
3	亡羊补牢	wáng yáng bǔ láo	Fixing the pen after the sheep are lost	Acting to correct a mistake too late.
4	塞翁失马	sāi wēng shī mǎ	The old man lost his horse	Life is unpredictable; good fortune can come from misfortune.
5	拔苗助长	bá miáo zhù zhǎng	Pulling up seedlings to help them grow	Acting hastily and ruining the situation.
6	井底之蛙	jǐng dǐ zhī wā	A frog at the bottom of the well	A person with a narrow perspective, lacking knowledge of the outside world.
7	鸡犬不宁	jī quǎn bù níng	The chicken and dog are not at peace	A chaotic situation.
8	自相矛盾	zì xiāng máo dùn	Self-contradiction	Saying or doing things that contradict each other.
9	破釜沉舟	pò fǔ chén zhōu	Breaking the pot and sinking the boat	Determined to pursue something without looking back.
10	杯弓蛇影	bēi gōng shé yǐng	Seeing a snake shadow in the cup	Overreacting or being overly suspicious.
11	入木三分	rù mù sān fēn	Written in a forceful hand; penetrating; profound	Doing something futile and beyond one's ability.
12	狐假虎威	hú jiǎ hǔ wēi	The fox borrows the tiger's power	Using the power of others to intimidate or control.
13	胸有成竹	xiōng yǒu chéng zhú	Having bamboo in mind	Being well-prepared and ready for any situation.
14	掩耳盗铃	yǎn ěr dào líng	Covering the ears while stealing a bell	Deceiving oneself, thinking that one can fool others.
15	画龙点睛	huà lóng diǎn jīng	Drawing a dragon and adding the eyes	Adding a small detail that makes everything come to life.
16	水落石出	shuǐ luò shí chū	The water recedes and the rocks are revealed	The truth will eventually come to light.
17	如鱼得水	rú yú dé shuǐ	Like a fish in water	Being in a suitable environment where one's abilities can flourish.
18	举一反三	jǔ yī fǎn sān	Learn one and infer three	Quick thinking and the ability to learn efficiently.
19	青出于蓝	qīng chū yú lán	Blue comes from indigo; the student exceeds the master	A student surpasses the teacher.
20	饮水思源	yǐn shuǐ sī yuán	Drinking water and thinking of its source	Always being grateful to those who helped you.
21	骑虎难下	qí hǔ nán xià	Riding a tiger, hard to dismount	In a difficult situation where you can't stop, even though you know it's a mistake.
22	鸡毛蒜皮	jī máo suǎn pí	Chicken feathers and garlic skins	Trivial matters that are not worth focusing on.
23	否极泰来	pǐ jí tài lái	After adversity comes prosperity	After hardship, good fortune will follow.
24	四面楚歌	sì miàn chǔ gē	Surrounded by enemies	Being in a difficult situation with no way out.
25	孤掌难鸣	gū zhǎng nán míng	A single hand cannot clap	One person alone cannot accomplish something big.
26	天衣无缝	tiān yī wú fèng	The clothes of the heavens have no seams	Perfect, without any flaws or gaps.
27	雪中送炭	xué zhōng sòng tàn	Sending coal in the snow	Offering timely help when someone is in need.
28	九牛一毛	jiǔ niú yī máo	One hair of nine oxen	Something so small that it is insignificant compared to the whole.
29	守株待兔	shǒu zhū dài tù	Waiting by the tree for a rabbit	Relying on luck instead of working hard.
30	见风使舵	jiàn fēng shǐ duò	Adjusting the rudder with the wind	Changing one's stance based on the situation; being opportunistic.
31	马到成功	mǎ dào chéng gōng	Success upon arrival	Wishing someone immediate success.
32	胜不骄败不馁	shèng bù jiāo bài bù nǚ	Humble in victory, resilient in defeat	Remaining modest in success and determined in failure.
33	锦上添花	jīn shàng tiān huā	Adding flowers to the brocade	Making something already good even better.
34	顺手牵羊	shùn shǒu qiān yáng	Leading a sheep by the hand	Stealing something small or taking advantage of an opportunity.
35	杀鸡敬猴	shā jī jǐng hóu	Killing the chicken to warn the monkey	Punishing one to deter others.
36	鹤立鸡群	hè lì jī qún	A crane standing among chickens	Standing out and being superior among others.
37	害群之马	hài qún zhī mǎ	A horse that harms the herd	A person who brings trouble to a group.
38	对牛弹琴	duì niú tán qín	Playing the lute to a cow	Speaking in a way that others can't understand or appreciate.
39	以卵击石	yǐ luǎn jī shí	Throwing an egg against a rock	Doing something that is futile and beyond one's ability.
40	杯水车薪	bēi shuǐ chē xīn	A cup of water to put out a burning cart	A small effort that is too insignificant to solve a big problem.
41	春风得意	chūn fēng dé yì	Feeling proud like a spring breeze	Being extremely satisfied and successful in career or life.
42	画饼充饥	huà bǐng chōng jī	Drawing a cake to fill hunger	Making unrealistic promises or having false hopes.
43	纸上谈兵	zhǐ shàng tán bīng	Talking about warfare on paper	Talking in theory without practical experience.
44	水滴石穿	shuǐ dī shí chuān	Dripping water can penetrate stone	Persistence leads to success.
45	狼狈为奸	láng bèi wéi jiān	The wolf and the rat collaborating	Two wrongdoers working together to do something illicit.
46	欲速则不达	yù sù zé bù dá	Haste makes waste	Rushing leads to failure; patience is required.
47	打草惊蛇	dǎ cǎo jīng shé	Striking the grass to scare the snake	Making a move that could alert others prematurely.
48	狗急跳墙	gǒu jí tiào qiáng	A dog in a hurry jumps over the wall	Desperate actions when one is cornered.
49	吃里扒外	chī lǐ pá wài	Eating a tree apple and hopping over a fig tree	Taking advantage of one place while benefiting another.
50	扶摇直上	fú yáo zhí shàng	Rising like a kite in the wind	Rapid and remarkable progress.

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51	虚张声势	xū zhāng shēng shì	Empty barrel makes the most noise	Talking big without having real strength.
52	千钧一发	qiān jūn yī fà	A thousand pounds hanging by a hair	A very dangerous or risky moment.
53	盲人摸象	mǎng rén mō xiàng	A blind man touches an elephant	Understanding a situation based on partial information.
54	百发百中	bǎi fā bǎi zhōng	A hundred shots, a hundred hits	Achieving success in every attempt.
55	鱼与熊掌不可兼得	yú hé xióng zhǎng bù kě jiān dé	You cannot have both fish and bear's paws	You can't have everything; choices must be made.
56	老马识途	lǎo mǎ shí tú	An old horse knows the way	A person with experience knows what to do.
57	狼心狗肺	láng xīn gǒu fèi	Wolf's heart, dog's lungs	A person with a vicious, heartless nature.
58	乐不思蜀	lè bù sī shǔ	Happy, forget the Shu Kingdom	Enjoying the present so much that you forget the past.
59	东山再起	dōng shān zài qǐ	Rising again on Mount Dong	To bounce back after setbacks or failure.
60	猫哭老鼠	māo kū lǎo shǔ	The cat cries for the mouse	Feigning sympathy, but with a hidden agenda.
61	千里之堤毁于蚁穴	qiān lǐ zhī dī huǐ yú yǐ xué	A thousand-mile dam collapses due to an ant hole	Small errors or issues can lead to larger consequences.
62	金无足赤	jīn wú zú chì	Gold is not pure	No one or nothing is without flaws.
63	退一步海阔天空	tuì yī bù hǎi kuò tiān kōng	Step back, and the sea and sky open up	Taking a step back can create more possibilities.
64	龙生龙，凤生凤	lóng shēng lóng, fèng shēng fèng	Dragons give birth to dragons, phoenixes give birth to phoenixes	Children resemble their parents or ancestors.
65	笨鸟先飞	bèn niǎo xiān fēi	A slow bird flies first	If you're not the best, you need to start early and work harder.
66	按图索骥	àn tú suǒ jì	Looking for a horse based on a picture	Following a plan or rule without adaptation to the situation.
67	鹬蚌相争，渔翁得利	yù bàng xiāng zhēng, yú wēng dé lì	The clam and the snipe fight, and the fisherman profits	Two parties fighting leads to a third party benefiting.
68	青黄不接	qīng huáng bù jiē	The green and yellow do not connect	When there's a gap or shortage, something is missing.
69	鸡犬升天	jī quǎn shēng tiān	The chicken and dog rise to the sky	One person's success brings benefits to everyone connected to them.
70	方枘圆凿	fāng ruì yuán záo	A square peg in a round hole	When two things don't match or fit together.
71	大海捞针	dà hǎi lāo zhēn	Searching for a needle in the sea	Something that is extremely difficult or nearly impossible.
72	一言九鼎	yī yán jiǔ dǐng	One word worth nine tripods	A word or promise that holds great importance or value.
73	一针见血	yī zhēn jiàn xuè	The wind comes from a hole	An action or statement that addresses the heart of the issue.
74	隔岸观火	gé àn guān huǒ	Watching the fire from the opposite bank	Watching something unfold from a distance without getting involved.
75	种瓜得瓜，种豆得豆	zhōng guā dé guā, zhōng dòu dé dòu	One needle, goes straight to the blood	Your actions determine your results.
76	引狼入室	yǐn láng rù shì	Bringing a wolf into the house	Allowing a dangerous situation to develop or bring harm.
77	口蜜腹剑	kǒu mì fù jiàn	Honey in the mouth, a sword in the belly	A person who hides malicious intentions behind a friendly exterior.
78	叶公好龙	yè gōng hào lóng	Duke Ye loves dragons	Appearing to like or support something, but not really.
79	空穴来风	kōng xué lái fēng	Lifting a stone and smashing your foot	There is always some truth behind every rumor.
80	临渊羡鱼	lín yuān xiàn yú	Admiring fish in the abyss	Wishing for something without taking the necessary steps.
81	草船借箭	cǎo chuán jiè jiàn	Borrowing arrows with a straw boat	Using the environment or circumstances to achieve success.
82	纸包不住火	zhǐ bāo bù zhù huǒ	Paper cannot wrap fire	The truth cannot be hidden forever.
83	过河拆桥	guò hé chāi qiáo	Breaking the bridge after crossing the river	Showing ingratitude after receiving help or benefits.
84	朝三暮四	zhāo sān mù sì	Three in the morning, four in the evening	Constantly changing one's mind or being unreliable.
85	指鹿为马	zhǐ lù wéi mǎ	Calling a deer a horse	Deliberately lying or misrepresenting something.
86	树欲静而风不止	shù yù jìng ér fēng bù zhǐ	The tree wants to be still, but the wind won't stop	Wanting peace but being disturbed by external forces.
87	搬起石头砸自己的脚	bān qǐ shí tóu dǎ zì jǐ de jiǎo	Lifting a stone and smashing your own foot	Bringing harm to oneself by trying to hurt someone else.
88	竹篮打水	zhú lán dǎ shuǐ	A bamboo basket fetching water	An attempt that will result in failure or waste.
89	隔墙有耳	gé qiáng yǒu ěr	The wall has ears	Someone is always listening or eavesdropping.
90	船到桥头自然直	chuán dào qiáo tóu zì rán zhí	The boat will straighten itself when it reaches the bridge	Things will work out when the time comes.
91	冰冻三尺，非一日之寒	bīng dòng sān chǐ, fēi yī rì zhī hán	Ice three feet thick doesn't form in a day	Major issues arise from long-term accumulation.
92	水中捞月	shuǐ zhōng lāo yuè	Fishing for the moon in the water	Trying to achieve something unattainable.
93	远水不救近火	yuǎn shuǐ bù jiù jìn huǒ	Distant water cannot save a nearby fire	Help from afar is useless for urgent problems.
94	临渴掘井	lín kě jué jǐng	Digging a well when thirsty	Not preparing until the last minute, when it's already urgent.
95	螳臂当车	táng bì dāng chē	A mantis blocking a chariot	Trying something impossible or beyond one's capability.
96	独木难支	dú mù nán zhī	One tree can't support a building	A single person cannot solve a major issue alone.
97	夜长梦多	yè cháng mèng duō	Long night, many dreams	The longer you wait, the more issues will emerge.
98	卧薪尝胆	wò xīn cháng dǎn	Sleeping on firewood and tasting bile	Going through extreme hardship for a future benefit.
99	走马观花	zǒu mǎ guān huā	Riding a horse, looking at flowers	Only seeing things briefly or superficially.
100	水能载舟，亦能覆舟	shuǐ néng zài zhōu, yì néng fù zhōu	Water can carry a boat, but it can also capsize it	Every situation has its advantages and risks.